A HISTORICAL ATLAS · COMPANION

The Order of Creation.

In the era of the Fatimid caliphate (909–1171), the Ismāʿīlī Shīʿī caliphate that rivaled the Abbasids from North Africa and then Cairo, Ismāʿīlī thinkers built a Neoplatonic account of how the world comes from God. The version drawn here follows Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī's *Paradise of Submission*, written in the thirteenth century while he worked among the Nizārī Ismāʿīlīs of Alamut, as presented in lecture, with details from the week's readings. Read it from top to bottom: each level comes from the one above it.

al-Mubdiʿ

The Originator

Above both the existent and the non-existent, and beyond every name and attribute. He cannot be proved or described, and He is not a cause: nothing of Him passes into what He originates.

Nāṣir Khusraw, 84; De Smet, 315; Walker, 81–82

ibdāʿ · origination from nothing, all at once

A break, not an arrow: origination is not emanation.

De Smet, 315; Walker, 82

I

ORIGINATION
·
ibdāʿ

one being, made from nothing, all at once, outside time

al-amr · al-kalima · kun

The Command, the Word ("Be!")

The single originated being, in which "all existences and existents were gathered together … all at once from nothing," like a whole tree in its seed. "Be!" is a metaphor: the Originator Himself has no word or command.

Nāṣir Khusraw, 28; De Smet, 317–18

one being, “two only in speech” (Nāṣir Khusraw, 85)

al-ʿaql al-awwal · al-sābiq · Kūnī

The First Intellect

The first originated being and the true First Cause. It holds the forms of all things, and the names Scripture gives God, even "*Allāh*," apply to it. Also called "the Preceder."

Ṭūsī, 19; De Smet, 317–19; Walker, 83

II

PROCESSION

inbiʿāth

the intelligible world proceeds from the Intellect

The Intellect thinks in three ways (Ṭūsī, 21)

Thinking of its cause

ʿaql

Another intellect

The next intellect in the chain.

Thinking of itself as necessary through another

al-nafs al-kulliyya

The Universal Soul

The soul of the sphere of spheres: imperfect and in motion, it longs for the Intellect. For Nāṣir Khusraw it is "the Creator and agent [of creation] in reality."

Ṭūsī, 21; Walker, 83; Nāṣir Khusraw, 27

Thinking of itself as possible in itself

jism

The body of the sphere of spheres

The first body, also called the Throne.

continues into Band III

Ṭūsī, 21

The Soul thinks in two ways (Ṭūsī, 22)

Contemplating the Intellect's perfection

ṣūra

Form

From "the category of perfection."

Contemplating its own deficiency

hayūlā

Matter

From "the category of deficiency."

Ṭūsī, 22

III

GENERATION · the compound world

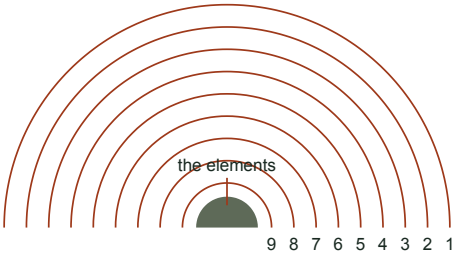
bodies of form and matter, subject to time and change

al-aflāk

The nine rotating spheres

Each sphere has "a governing soul" and "a determining intellect"; each sphere's intellect gives rise to the next sphere down.

Ṭūsī, quoted in Lecture 9.2



1. Sphere of spheres (the Throne)
2. Fixed stars
3. Saturn
4. Jupiter
5. Mars
6. Sun
7. Venus
8. Mercury
9. Moon

al-ʿaql al-faʿʿāl · wāhib al-ṣuwar

The Agent Intellect, the Form-Giver

The intellect of the Moon's sphere and the last of the ten intellects, "responsible for the actualisation of all potential things in this world."

Ṭūsī, quoted in Lecture 9.2

al-ʿanāṣir

The four elements

Earth, water, air and fire, "arranged in the interior of the sphere of the Moon … through the yearning movement of the spheres."

Ṭūsī, quoted in Lecture 9.2

al-mawālīd

The natural kingdoms

Mineral, plant and animal, each given by the Form-Giver "suitable forms together with their own particular concomitants."

Ṭūsī, quoted in Lecture 9.2

al-insān

The human being

The fruit of the whole world: the last and fullest receiver of the Intellect's light and the Soul's trace, and so capable of rationality and discrimination.

Lecture 9.2; Nāṣir Khusraw, 64; Walker, 80

↓ *taʾyīd* · inspiration: The Intellect gives the Prophet a non-verbal inspiration, which he translates into the language of his people. (De Smet, 318; Lecture 9.2)

↑ *taʾwīl* · esoteric interpretation: The imāms trace scripture's literal, outer meaning back to its inner source in the Intellect, leading the soul upward. (Walker, 84; Lecture 9.2)

Mirror: In the world of religion, the Intellect's counterpart is the *nāṭiq*, the enunciator-prophet, and the Soul's is the *asās*, the founder-imām. (Nāṣir Khusraw, 65)

Ismāʿīlī cosmology after Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī. The three bands follow the readings' distinction between origination, procession and generation (Walker, 82; Nāṣir Khusraw, 29).

Reading the scheme

This diagram shows the Ismāʿīlī account of creation, after Naṣīr al-Dīn al-Ṭūsī; each level comes from the one above it. The Ismāʿīlīs borrowed this ladder of emanation from Neoplatonism but placed God outside it. If the world flowed out of God, He would share His being with it and cease to be absolutely one. The Originator (*al-Mubdiʿ*) therefore originates the first being from nothing and all at once (*ibdāʿ*) without causing it, so a break, not an arrow, separates Him from everything below. He cannot be described or even named. That first being, the Command or Word, is one with the First Intellect, which does the work philosophers assign to God: it is the First Cause, and every divine name, even "*Allāh*," applies to it. Below it, the arrows mark ordinary emanation (*inbiʿāth*). The Intellect's self-reflection yields the Soul, the Soul's awareness of its deficiency yields matter, and the chain descends through the spheres to elements, plants, animals and humans, each less perfect than the last. It also runs upward: the Intellect inspires the Prophet (*taʾyīd*), and esoteric interpretation (*taʾwīl*) leads the soul back toward it (Lecture 9.2; Ṭūsī, 19–22; Nāṣir Khusraw, 85; De Smet, 315–19; Walker, 81–83).

Other versions

Ismāʿīlī cosmology was never one fixed system. Nāṣir Khusraw, who often follows al-Sijistānī, has one Intellect and one Soul: the Word and the Intellect are "two only in speech," and the Soul makes the spheres, the seven planets and the elements from prime matter as its own body (Nāṣir Khusraw, 27, 38–40, 85; Walker, 78). Ḥamīd al-Dīn al-Kirmānī (d. after 1020) replaces the Intellect–Soul pair with ten intellects on al-Fārābī's model (Walker, 84–87). Al-Ṭūsī, writing after Avicenna, adopts Avicenna's ten intellects and the Intellect's threefold self-knowledge while keeping the Originator above the whole chain (Lecture 9.2).

Sources

1. van Dalen, Elaine. "Lecture 9.2: Ismāʿīlī Theology." Intro to Islamic Civilization, Columbia University, November 4, 2026. Lecture slides.
2. al-Ṭūsī, Naṣīr al-Dīn. *Paradise of Submission: A Medieval Treatise on Ismaili Thought (Rawḍa-yi taslīm)*. Edited and translated by S. J. Badakhchani. London: I.B. Tauris in association with the Institute of Ismaili Studies, 2005. Quoted from Lecture 9.2.
3. Nāṣir Khusraw. *Knowledge and Liberation: A Treatise on Philosophical Theology*. A new edition and English translation of the *Gushāyish wa rahāyish* by Faquir M. Hunzai, with an introduction and commentary by Parviz Morewedge. London: I.B. Tauris in association with the Institute of Ismaili Studies, 1998.
4. De Smet, Daniel. "Ismāʿīlī Theology." In *The Oxford Handbook of Islamic Theology*, edited by Sabine Schmidtke, 313–24. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014. (https://doi.org/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780199696703.013.010)
5. Walker, Paul E. "The Ismāʿīlīs." In *The Cambridge Companion to Arabic Philosophy*, edited by Peter Adamson and Richard C. Taylor, 72–91. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005. (https://doi.org/10.1017/CCOL0521817439.005)

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